To: Tech Nation UK

20-22 Wenlock Road,

London, N1 7GU

Mar 15, 2026.

PERSONAL ENDORSEMENT FOR UK GLOBAL TALENT

I'm Nitin Muthyala, co-founder of HitPay, a payments infrastructure company out of Y Combinator's S21 batch. We're deployed across Southeast Asia. I hired Raphael Obodugo as our founding frontend engineer in 2023. This letter is about what I observed.

When you're hiring a founding engineer at a payments company, the usual résumé signals matter less than one specific thing: judgment under constraint. Payments infrastructure is unforgiving. You can't ship fast and fix it later when a bug means a merchant's settlement is wrong. The decisions a founding engineer makes in the first months shape the system for years. I hired Raphael because I assessed his judgment as sound. That assessment proved correct.

He built the design system that became the foundation for everything the frontend engineering team at HitPay worked from. It was clean, well-considered, and built with the clear awareness that other engineers would have to live inside it, not just the person who designed it. That last quality is underrated. A lot of strong individual engineers build for themselves. Raphael built for the team.

What I also observed was that this wasn't someone who needed the HitPay stamp to be credible. He had already been accepted into Toptal, a network that accepts fewer than 3% of applicants, years before working with us. He was already thinking about building his own company in West Africa. The MySub outcome, a bootstrapped fintech product that reached 360,000 users and was eventually acquired, followed directly from that intent. He told me what he was building. He then built it.

He's now developing AVAE, an AI company, and plans to operate from the UK. I don't write many of these letters. I'm writing this one because I have seen enough founders and early engineers to have a calibrated view of who compounds and who doesn't. Raphael compounds.

The UK gets a founder who has already shipped at scale, under regulatory constraint, across multiple markets. That's not a common profile.

I'm writing this because the Global Talent Visa exists for people who have already proven what they can do, and Raphael has. He has my full recommendation.

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